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Singapore PM Wong sends condolences to China over death of former premier Zhu Rongji



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Zhu Rongji, who served as China's premier from 1998 to 2003, died from illness on Wednesday at the age of 97.



Former Chinese Premier Zhu Rongji waves to reporters upon arrival at Singapore's Changi Airport to attend the fourth ASEAN Informal Summit meeting on Nov 23, 2000. (Photo: AFP/Roslan Rahman)

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SINGAPORE: Prime Minister Lawrence Wong on Thursday (Aug 13) conveyed his condolences to Chinese Premier Li Qiang, following [the death of former Chinese Premier Zhu Rongji](#).

Zhu, who served as China's premier from 1998 to 2003, died from illness on Wednesday morning at the age of 97.

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Mr Wong described Zhu as an "old friend of Singapore" who played an important role in strengthening ties between the two countries.

In a condolence letter to Premier Li, Mr Wong wrote that Zhu had demonstrated "remarkable foresight and resolve" over his long career in public service, particularly in advancing China's economic reforms and leading the country's accession to the World Trade Organization in 2001.

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"Premier Zhu will long be remembered for his distinguished contributions to China's development and to Singapore-China relations", said Mr Wong.

Zhu met Singapore's former prime ministers Lee Kuan Yew and Goh Chok Tong on many occasions.

In 1999, he became the first Chinese leader to deliver the Singapore Lecture, a high-profile public platform organised by the ISEAS – Yusof Ishak Institute for world leaders and experts to share their views on regional and global developments.

Mr Wong said Zhu's speech reflected his strategic vision that China's economic development and growth would benefit Asia and the world. Zhu also proposed a free-trade area between ASEAN and China so as to deepen economic ties, said Mr Wong.

"Today, his vision has been borne out, with China an important economic partner for Singapore and countries across the region."

Zhu was also an early supporter of the China-Singapore Suzhou Industrial Park, the first government-to-government project between the two countries. During his earlier stint as mayor of Shanghai, Zhu also encouraged exchanges and mutual learning between officials from Singapore and Shanghai.

"These efforts laid a strong foundation for the close ties and extensive exchanges that our two countries enjoy today," said Mr Wong.

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Chinese Premier Zhu Rongji (centre right) inspects a guard-of-honour ceremony held at the Istana in Singapore on Nov 29, 1999 with Singapore Prime Minister Goh Chok Tong. (File photo: AFP)

The former premier is credited with helping drive China's economic rise through his market reforms, which included privatising unprofitable state-owned enterprises and urban housing, and promoting home ownership.

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On the global economic front, he paved China's entry into the World Trade Organization through intense negotiations, though many Chinese officials at that time feared he had made so many concessions that the country's economy would be hobbled.

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An obituary jointly issued by China's top political bodies hailed Zhu as "an outstanding member of the Communist Party of China".

"The life of comrade Zhu Rongji was a life of revolution, a life of struggle, a life of glory," it said.

"It was a life dedicated wholeheartedly to serving the people, one given to the communist cause. His passing is a major loss for the party and the country."

Source: CNA/Agencies/rl

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